

Prefer, Would Prefer & Would Rather Uncovered

Unsure about when to use prefer, would prefer and would rather? This lesson clears up the confusion and shows you how to talk about habits and general and specific preferences with confidence. You'll learn the grammar, spot common mistakes and practise with mini quizzes. By the end, you'll be using prefer, would prefer and would rather accurately, whether you're ordering dinner or telling someone what you wish they'd done differently.

General Preferences with 'Prefer'

prefer = choose one thing over another / like one thing better than another

'Prefer' can refer to general preferences — things we usually like or choose over others. For example:

- I **prefer dogs** to humans sometimes.
- He **prefers binge-watching** Netflix to going to parties.
- They **prefer to drink** French wine over Italian.

'Prefer' is usually followed by:

a noun (**dogs**)

the -ing form (**binge-watching**)

the to-infinitive (**to drink**)



We can also use **prefer that**. This is more formal.

- "We **prefer that** guests remove shoes before entering."

Prefer + -ing / to-infinitive

We can use '**prefer + ing**' or '**prefer + to-infinitive**' with little difference in meaning. But we often use -ing to put the focus on the action and express that we really enjoy it. For example:

"We **prefer taking** the train to driving." (We enjoy taking the train more than driving.)

We might choose the to-infinitive when we want to focus on the habit or the result.

- We **prefer to take** the train on weekday mornings. (We do this as a habit and perhaps because it's easier than driving on those days.)

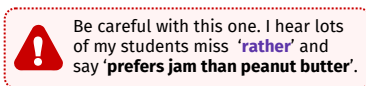
The focus is often narrower with 'prefer to'. For example, we might say '**on weekday mornings**', '**on Sunday afternoons**', '**when I'm not feeling well**'.

Prefer to / over / rather than

prefer ___ to	prefer ___ over
to prefer sth. to sth.	to prefer sth. over sth.
• I prefer dogs to humans sometimes. • He prefers binge-watching Netflix to going to parties.	• They prefer to drink French wine over Italian.

We can also say we prefer something **rather than** something.

- She prefers jam **rather than** peanut butter.
- She prefers to stay at home **rather than** go out. (We use the base form after rather than.)



We can use **rather than** to mean **instead of**, particularly when saying we prefer one thing over another. It's often followed by an -ing form.

- **Rather than** going abroad this summer, we decided to have a holiday in the UK.
- It's good to learn to drive **rather than** relying on public transport if you live in the countryside.

Preference without repeating the options

We don't always have to follow 'prefer' with 2 things. Often, the comparison is obvious.

- Do you like coffee?
 - I **prefer** tea. (The speaker doesn't need to repeat 'coffee'.)

Questions with 'prefer'

We often use 'prefer' in questions, and the options tend to be connected with 'or', like this:

- Do you **prefer** summer or winter?
- Does he **prefer** reading books or watching films?

Specific Preferences: 'Would Prefer' and 'Would Rather'

If we want to talk about preference on a specific occasion, we use 'would prefer + noun or to-infinitive':

- "Do you fancy pizza or pasta tonight?"
 - "I'd **prefer** pizza."
 - or
 - "I'd **prefer to have** pizza."

That's to talk about specific preferences in the present or future.

A synonym for '**would prefer**' is '**would rather**', or its more common contraction, 'I'd rather'. We use 'would rather + base verb'.

- "I'd **rather** have pizza."

Formal vs informal tone

'Would rather' is more common in casual conversation. 'Would prefer' is a bit more formal, though both are usually contracted in speech: 'I'd rather', 'she'd prefer'. And, 'would rather' is often used to express preferences about actions, so it's usually followed by a verb.

Other subjects

The subject doesn't have to be 'I'. We can use other subjects, though we don't really use 'it':



- He'd **prefer** to order a burger.
- We'd **rather** try Thai food.

Another couple of examples:

- I'd **prefer** to take the train **rather than** fly.
- I'd **rather** take the train **than** fly.

Now, what do you notice about the words joining or comparing the 2 preferences? After 'would prefer', we often use 'rather than'. Notice that 'rather than' is followed by the base verb, 'fly', not 'to fly'. Another example:

- We'd **prefer** to take the dog on holiday **rather than leave** him behind.

After 'would rather', we simply use 'than'.

We can use **to** or **over** when those words can be followed by a noun or gerund.

- I'd **prefer** to stay in a hotel **to** an Airbnb.
- I'd **prefer** to stay in a hotel **over** an Airbnb.

Using 'much' for emphasis

To make a preference stronger, we can add 'much'. In speech, we stress 'much'.

- I'd **much rather** stay in a hotel.
- I'd **much prefer** to stay in a hotel.

Preference or wish

Alright, now look at this sentence. Does it express a preference for one thing over another or something else?

- I'd **rather like to stay** in a hotel that offers breakfast.

That sentence doesn't express preference directly. In this expression, 'rather' means 'quite'.

- I'd **quite like to stay** in a hotel that offers breakfast.

To express a preference, we say:

- I'd **rather stay** in a hotel that offers breakfast than one that doesn't.

or

- I'd **prefer to stay** in a hotel that offers breakfast rather than in an Airbnb.

Making Negative Sentences

How do we make these sentences negative? Where do we add 'not'?

- They'd prefer to fly. → They'd **prefer not to fly**.
= would prefer not + to-infinitive
- They'd rather fly. → They'd **rather not fly**.
= would rather not + base verb

We can also use short answers, like this:

- Do you want to talk about it?
 - I'd **prefer not to**.
 - I'd **rather not**.

Asking Questions

Forming questions is actually quite simple: we just put **would** before the subject.

- **Would you prefer to go** to France or Spain? (with the to-infinitive)
- **Would you rather go** to France or Spain? (with the base verb)

Talking About Past Preferences

If we want to talk about specific preferences in the past, we can use a perfect infinitive: that's either '**to have + past participle**' or '**have + past participle**'. For example:

- Last year, we went to Cornwall, but...
 - I'd **prefer to have gone** to Spain.
 - I'd **rather have gone** to Spain.

We can also use this structure:

- I'd have preferred to go to Spain.

That's 'would have preferred + to-infinitive'.



Would have preferred + to-infinitive and **would prefer to have + past participle** are both correct.

- I **would have preferred to stay** at home.
- I **would prefer to have stayed** at home.

Would have rather + past participle is not very common. **Would rather have + past participle** is the more widely used and accepted structure:

- I **would rather have stayed** at home.



Use '**prefer**' for general preferences.

Use '**would prefer + to-infinitive**' or '**would rather + base verb**' for specific situations.

Quiz Questions & Answers

Complete the gap with 'prefer' or 'rather'.

1. I _____ reading books to watching films.

Complete the sentence to make a statement about preferences.

2. I would rather _____ a year in the Arctic.

- to spend
- spend
- like to spend

Make this sentence past tense.

3. I'd rather live by the sea.

1. prefer 2. spend 3. I'd rather have lived by the sea.



Preferences with Different Subjects

We've looked at how to express preferences when the clauses refer to the same person. For example, 'I'd rather stay in a hotel.' I want this and I'm the one who'll be staying there. But what if we're talking about someone else's actions and the 2 clauses refer to different people? Let's find out!

'I'd rather you + past tense' for present/future

We'll start with 'would rather'. What time are we talking about in these examples? Past, present or future?

- I'd rather you **asked** before you borrow my car again.
- We'd rather he **didn't tell** Mum about this.

The sentences refer to the present or future, but we use a past tense. 'You asked' and 'he didn't'. The structure is:

subject 1 + would rather + subject 2 + past simple/continuous tense



I'd rather you asked.

There is another structure we can use to talk about present and future preferences — **the subjunctive** — but this is less common.

We use the subjunctive mood to express wishes, possibility or uncertainty. In the present tense, it is the base form of the verb. Here are some examples with 'would rather':

- I'd rather they **be** told today.
- We'd rather Jun **arrive** a little earlier.

However, the subjunctive is not very common in English. You're more likely to hear those sentences like this:

- I'd rather they **were** told today. ✓
- We'd rather Jun **arrived** earlier. ✓

'I'd rather you had...' for past preferences

When we want to talk about the past, we can use the past perfect:

- **I'd rather you hadn't booked** such an early flight!

The structure is:

subject 1 + would rather + subject 2 + past perfect

But we'd usually use **'wish'** instead.

- **I wish you hadn't booked** such an early flight!

'Prefer ___ to...' vs 'prefer it if ___...'

We can also use 'would prefer' with 2 different subjects. There are 2 main structures.

- **I'd prefer him to take** the middle seat.



subject 1 + would prefer + object pronoun + to-infinitive

- **I'd prefer it if he took** the middle seat.



subject 1 + would prefer + it if + subject 2 + past tense (🎯 more common)



Many students miss out **'it'**, so try to learn the structure as a chunk: **I'd prefer it if...**

Making It Negative

To make negative sentences, we use **'not'** or **'didn't'**.

- **I'd prefer you not to go** over there anymore.
- **I'd prefer it if you didn't eat** chocolate ice cream on the sofa.

Talking About the Past with Two Subjects

When talking about the past with 'prefer', if we have 2 subjects, a common structure is **subject 1 + would have preferred + noun / object pronoun + to-infinitive**.

- **I would have preferred her to stay** a bit longer.

Quiz Questions & Answers

Complete the answer to this question with 'don't', 'not' or 'didn't'

1. A: Would you mind if I opened the window?

B: I'd rather you _____.

Complete the gap with 2 words.

2. I would prefer _____ you didn't call so late.

Is this correct or incorrect?

3. I'd rather you had waited until I arrived before ordering.

1. didn't 2. if 3. correct

Can You Spot the Mistakes?

Now that you've completed the lesson and understand how these structures work, let's go back to the sentences we looked at at the beginning of the lesson on YouTube. Can you decide which ones are correct and incorrect?

I prefer to eat dessert first.

✓ **Correct:** This is a general preference. You usually or always prefer this.

I'd rather to eat dessert first.

✗ **Incorrect:** We don't use to after would rather. This expresses a preference on a specific occasion.

✓ I'd rather eat dessert first.

She prefers beaches over mountains.

✓ **Correct**



She prefers beaches to mountains.

✓ **Correct:** Both over and to are fine when comparing nouns.

I'd rather like to come with you.

✓ Grammatically correct, but it doesn't directly express preference for one thing over another. It means 'I'd quite like to come with you'.

To express preference:

✓ I'd rather come with you.

Bonus Lesson: would sooner

Would sooner means the same as **would rather**. It's also followed by the same grammatical structures. **Would rather** is more common than **would sooner**.
Examples:

1. We'd **sooner learn** Italian **than** English.
would sooner + base verb (... + than)

This refers to the present or future and both clauses refer to the same person or thing.

2. I'd **sooner have spoken** to him in person.
would sooner + have + past participle

This refers to the past and both clauses refer to the same person or thing.

3. I'd **sooner we got** a cat than a dog.
subject 1 + would sooner + subject 2 + past simple/continuous tense

This refers to the present or future and the clauses have different subjects (I vs we).



Quiz

For each question, choose the correct answer from the options provided.

1. Choose the correct sentence.

- a) I'd rather to stay in this evening.
- b) I'd rather stay in this evening.
- c) I'd prefer stay in this evening.

2. Which option below CANNOT complete the sentence?

"She prefers reading novels _____ watching films."

- a) to
- b) rather than
- c) over than

3. Which sentence is NOT grammatically correct?

- a) I'd rather you hadn't mentioned it.
- b) I'd rather we booked the table early.
- c) I'd prefer if we leave now.

4. What does the sentence below express?

"I'd rather like a slice of that cake."

- a) A general preference
- b) A want or wish
- c) A strong objection

5. Choose the correct past-tense structure (same subject).

- a) I'd rather have stayed.
- b) I'd rather to have stayed.
- c) I'd rather had stayed.

6. Choose the correct sentence (different subjects, present or future).

- a) I'd rather he told me directly.
- b) I'd rather he tells me directly.
- c) I'd rather he will tell me directly.

7. Complete the question.

"Would you prefer _____ this evening or to cook at home?"

- a) to eat out
- b) eat out
- c) ate out

8. Which sentence correctly uses would sooner?

- a) I'd sooner finding out earlier.
- b) I'd sooner to have found out earlier.
- c) I'd sooner he didn't find out.

Answers:

1. b 2. c 3. c 4. a 5. a 6. b 7. a 8. b

